

With the rapid development of technology exemplified by artificial intelligence, automation, and telecommunications, humanity is now more capable than ever before, creating abundance, ensuring convenience, and accessing information where scarcity once ruled.¹ Yet such promises hide a profound uncertainty: what does it mean to harness technology for the “social good”?² The phrase conceals an ambiguity that Socrates would have challenged. As if we do not fully understand what is good, our efforts to achieve it may, paradoxically, lead us away from it. Therefore, the challenge is not only how to harness technological power, but how to understand the moral spectrum within which “good” itself resides.³

Socrates’ method of inquiry, the Socratic method, of insisting on questioning assumed truths through logical argumentation, offers a starting point to define “social good.” In Plato’s dialogues, Socrates confronts scholars and leaders who claimed to know the full meaning of justice, virtue, or goodness, only to reveal contradictions in their reasoning.⁴ In the same manner, modern society takes for granted that technology will serve the common good but rarely discusses the “good” they aim to pursue.⁵ Depending on perspectives, it can mean economic prosperity, equity and well-being, efficiency, or freedom. These interpretations often conflict with each other, and technology amplifies the values of its creators. Thus, when new technology is claimed to be used for the “social good,” it is not describing an objective reality but projecting a moral preference. Without examining such a preference, progress risks become erratic.⁶

AI epitomizes this tension. Algorithms that prioritize efficiency may inadvertently sacrifice empathy. Systems built to predict human behavior can entrench the very biases they seek to overcome.⁷ An algorithm once tested by Amazon for resume screening to efficiently select applicants showed bias against females, giving lower recommendations for them.⁸ When an AI is charged with the responsibility of making a choice, such as deciding who receives medical care, who gains employment, or who is granted parole, its logic reflects not an impartial morality but the assumptions embedded by its designers.⁹ This might be seen as the epitome of rationality for the uncritical mind, but for the Socratic mind, it is rather a warning. Socrates philosophized that unexamined virtue is not virtue at all. Similarly, unexamined technology, even coated with assumed “good,” risks becoming a tool of unseen harm.

Automation has been developing since the Industrial Revolution to focus on better efficiency of resources. It allowed mass production, achieving productive efficiency and cheaper costs, shown through a 25% increase in labor productivity across sectors¹⁰ and 31% of business leaders citing reduced labor cost as a result of automation.¹¹ Furthermore, Goldman Sachs predicts that up to 50% of jobs could be fully automated by 2045.¹² Even though machines can provide abundance in materials and technological prosperity, automation itself raises questions of purpose and dignity, as human replacement can liberate us from drudgery or rob us of meaning. From a Socratic perspective, the tension between convenience and meaningfulness should be understood, not mindlessly advocating one side of the consequences.

With the advent of communication platforms, humanity can communicate more easily than ever before, but the duality of vice and virtue can also be found, ironically amplifying division. As there is convenient accessibility of information, it has become harder to distinguish truth from fake news and AI-generated works. A study suggests that over 50% of new online articles include AI-generated writings.¹³ The problem is that content often includes misleading information or encourages certain biases in accordance with the creator's intention.⁹ This would not only create division amongst the ideologies of people but also create overall chaos in determining the veracity of the media. The Socratic inquiry should be implemented in developing communications technologies to discuss the importance of accessibility and misinformation.

The problem of ethics and technology has been present throughout human history. Yet, the misconception of equating technological advancements with moral advancement occurs rapidly, when technological progress often outpaces discussion of their moral implications.¹⁴ In comparison, nuclear physics enabled the finding of an immense amount of energy, but at the same time, its use as a nuclear weapon created massacres beyond measure.¹⁵ This lack of discussion regarding the ethics of new technology has inevitably brought consequences affecting the lives of people. For the same reason, new technologies such as artificial intelligence and other technological advances should be evaluated first with moral implications rather than their use via the vision of Socratic philosophy, which suggests being aware of the naivety of the possible consequences technology can bring, quoting, "There is only one good, knowledge, and one evil, ignorance."¹⁶

To achieve the "social good" cultivation of technologies, societies must embed philosophical reflection into technological creation.¹⁷ Ethics should not be an afterthought considered once harm occurs but an integral part of design. Governments should regulate technology not only based on economic outcomes but also consider morals, ensuring that human dignity is preserved over efficiency. Novel technologies must be discussed amongst not only developers but also philosophers and sociologists to discuss their socioethical impact(s) before the widespread adoption to solve or prepare for their impact. For future developers of technology, education should not only focus on teaching technical proficiency but also evolve to foster moral literacy of actions, enabling future innovators to question and analyze the social good in relation to their inventions. These solutions reflect the idea of Socratic inquiry, questioning the good to achieve a deeper understanding.

In conclusion, technology's capacity for development is both real and dangerous. However, to question the "good" does not mean to deny it. Technology has the potential to advance the lives of humans, of course. The Socratic insight is not rejecting technology but rather working as a lens, encouraging discussions of its implications to be used in a socially beneficial way. In this way, technology neither becomes an enlightenment nor a threat but a tool to be used with consciousness that aligns with the "good" mankind pursues.

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